



An artist's representation of the SpaceShipTwo in space

configuration allow for easy access to WhiteKnightTwo and the spaceship for passengers and crew; the design also aids operational efficiencies and turnaround times.

Perhaps the most innovative safety feature employed by SpaceshipOne and now SpaceShipTwo is the unique way it returns into the dense atmosphere from the vacuum of space. This part of space flight has always been considered as one of the most technically challenging and dangerous and Burt Rutan was determined to find a failsafe solution which remained true to Scaled Composite's philosophy of safety through simplicity. His inspiration for what is known as the feathered re-entry was the humble shuttlecock, which relies on aerodynamic design and laws of physics to control speed and attitude.

Once out of the atmosphere the entire tail structure of the spaceship can be rotated upwards to about 65 degrees. The feathered configuration allows an automatic control of attitude with the fuselage parallel to the horizon. This creates



The WhiteKnightTwo aircraft carrying the SpaceShipTwo before its further ascent into space